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1840, Fateh Singh

Bhagat Singh was born on 27 September 1907 in a small village by the name of ‘Banga’. It was then the Lyallpur district of undivided Indian Punjab. Today it is located in Pakistan under the new name of Faisalabad. The old name still persists though, and many continue to refer to it as Lyallpur district. Bhagat Singh’s origin lay, however, in the Jalandhar district in his family’s ancestral village of Khatkar Kalan, and this continues to remain on the Indian side of Punjab. Banga in Pakistan is not to be confused with Banga in India. The former is situated roughly 20 km from both Faisalabad and Jaranwala, and 133 km from Lahore. Banga town, just outside the village of Khatkar Kalyan in India, is named after Bhagat Singh. It is 8 km from Nawanshahr district, which was formed in 1995 from the districts of Hoshiarpur and Jalandhar in Indian Punjab. Nawanshahr in turn was renamed on 27 September 2008 as Shahid Bhagat Singh Nagar on the 101st birth anniversary of Bhagat Singh by Chief Minister Prakash Singh Badal. The two towns of Banga are manifestations of two representations of Bhagat Singh’s life—one in Pakistan and one in India.

So Bhagat Singh was born in Banga on the Pakistan side even though there is also a Banga named after him on the Indian side. In his birth, therefore, as in everything else that Bhagat Singh did in his short life, he made it possible for the two countries of India and Pakistan to be able to lay a claim on his person, and this despite the communal bloodshed that accompanied Independence in 1947 that pitched one community against the other. No other political leader, before Partition or since, has been able to achieve such a feat.